

Alberto Valz Gris

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Currently

Post-doctoral Research Fellow

Interuniversity Department of Regional and Urban Studies and Planning
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Research interests

Alberto Valz Gris is a critical urban geographer, currently a Post-doctoral Research Fellow at Politecnico di Torino. His research interests lie in a theoretically oriented and empirically grounded urban geography of global infrastructure and resource extraction. His recent projects have explored the dynamics of mineral extraction and the contested histories of infrastructural development drawing on fieldwork in different contexts, such as the lithium boom in the Atacama (Argentina and Chile) and the urban outcomes of port expansion in Piraeus (Greece) and Genova (Italy).

Education

- 2017–2021 **PhD in Urban and Regional Development**, Cum laude
Thesis: Hinterlands of the Green Transition. Atacama, Lithium and the Extended Geographies of the Zero-emission City
Politecnico di Torino, Italy
- 2014–2016 **MA in Fine Arts**
Sandberg Instituut, Amsterdam, The Netherlands
- 2011–2014 **MSc in Architecture, Construction, City**, 110/110
Thesis: Barcelona's Interstices, Opening up Architectural Practice
Politecnico di Torino, Italy
- 2009–2012 **BA in Architecture Sciences**, 106/110
Thesis: Osservare dal Parco. Un Progetto di Trasformazione per il Parco del Meisino
Politecnico di Torino, Italy

Research

- 2024–now **Urbanization, everyday life and techno-social differentiation – Global CORRIDOR**
Department of Urban and Regional Studies and Planning (DIST), Politecnico di Torino and University of Sheffield
Post-doctoral research fellow. Principal investigator: dr. Jonathan Silver
A five-year starting grant project commencing in July 2021 funded by the Horizon2020 programme, European Research Council. The project aims to outline the unequal impacts corridor investments are having on people living in cities during rapid urbanization and explore alternatives that might help better address urban inequality and sustainability.
- 2024–now **The new Italian geographies of logistics**
Department of Urban and Regional Studies and Planning (DIST), Politecnico di Torino
Post-doctoral research fellow. Principal investigator: prof. C. Salone
The project focuses on the new spatial articulations of the logistics sector in Italy, assuming that the logistics sector has grown significantly over the last 20 years and that this growth has determined several effects on the spatial organization of various places along the peninsula.
- 2023–now **The financialised city? Milano: geografie finanziarie, geopolitica urbana e questione abitativa**
Department of Urban and Regional Studies and Planning (DIST), Politecnico di Torino
Post-doctoral research fellow. Principal investigator: prof. F. Governa
This project explores the financialization of urban development, particularly in Milan after the 2008 financial crisis. Milan's transformation aligns with global trends, featuring strategic urban planning to position the city as a global hub. This involves initiatives like urban regeneration, major events, and population attraction, driving symbolic projects and substantial investments. This study charts a multiscale network involving diverse actors and objectives, examining theoretical aspects (urban geopolitics, state role, societal impacts) and empirical dimensions (financial architectures, strategies, and specific area transformations like Porta Romana). Milan's case contributes to international observations, depicting financialization as a multi-faceted, contradictory process with diverse actors beyond financial institutions. This research aims to illuminate Milan's urban dynamics, considering geopolitical implications and societal impacts, thus expanding the understanding of financialization in urban development globally.
- 2022–2024 **Rescaling the Belt and Road Initiative**
Department of Urban and Regional Studies and Planning (DIST), Politecnico di Torino

Post-doctoral research fellow. Principal investigator: prof. F. Governa

This research program, financed by the PRIN project "Rescaling the Belt and Road Initiative: urbanisation processes, innovation patterns and global investments in urban China", seeks to construct a dialogue between the international debate on Global Urbanism and the urban experience of Southern Europe. Global Urbanism emerges as the attempt to build critical urban knowledge starting from the grounded acknowledgment of differences and their continuous mutations. Through this project, we propose to explore the question of a global urban horizon starting from the specificities and differences of various Southern European urban experiences, hence attempting theory building from peripheral loci. In its initial phases, the program will consist in the critical analysis of existing research, in a selection of three case studies and in their subsequent exploration through short fieldwork periods.

2022

I paesaggi operazionali nel Nord Italia. Geografie mobili, strategie spaziali e mappe dinamiche dell'urbanizzazione regionale

Department of Architecture and Urban Studies (DASTU), Politecnico di Milano

Research consultant. Principal investigator: prof. S. Armondi

Which dynamics are reconfiguring those territories of production, circulation and support that exists in relation to large urban concentrations? This project—enabled by funding for original research by the Politecnico di Milano—critically investigates the geographies of operational landscapes in Northern Italian regions with three main goals. Firstly, it aims at tracing emergent economic geographies by updating their interpretive frameworks, cartographic representations and challenging impending urban dynamics. Secondly, it seeks to describe the plurality of policies, actors and strategies that remake urban contexts and territorial configurations; thirdly, it proposes to build evidence and spatial representations that support the activity of planners and policymakers with respect to the shifting dynamics of global production. In its initial phases, the project involves quantitative modeling, spot cartographic analysis and semi-structured interviews as a focus on case studies spanning the width of Northern Italian regions.

2021

Dream Story. Urban modernity through Italy and China

Department of Urban and Regional Studies and Planning (DIST), Politecnico di Torino

Research assistant. Principal investigator: prof. F. Governa

The project forms part of the activities financed by the PRIN project Rescaling the Belt and Road Initiative: urbanisation processes, innovation patterns and global investments in urban China, and consists in the design and production of an international exhibition and a multi-media catalog on the theme of urban modernities. Drawing on an openly comparative approach to patterns of urbanization, this research explores the emergence of multiple urban modernities by observing them through two apparently unrelated waves of urbanization: that of postwar Italy and that of contemporary China. My involvement in the project consists in supporting the curatorial team by critically selecting case studies and producing both theoretical, archival and field-based research on the driving themes of the exhibition.

2017–2021

Hinterlands of the green transition. Atacama, lithium and the extended geographies of the zero-emission city

Department of Urban and Regional Studies and Planning (DIST), Politecnico di Torino

Ph.D. candidate. Tutor: prof. F. Governa

This doctoral dissertation project explores the dynamics of lithium extraction on the Atacama plateau as an analytical move to understand flows of urban metabolism between cities and hinterlands at the planetary scale. Combining theoretical frameworks from the areas of critical urban studies, economic geography and urban political ecology, the project deepens our understanding of the persisting extractivism of urban green transitions. This argument has been developed through the deployment of ethnographic fieldwork in Argentina and Chile, document and cartographic analysis and visual methodologies. The completion of the project has involved autonomous research design, the organization and fulfillment of international fieldwork and a sustained program of discussion in international conferences and seminars.

Non-academic
research

2022–2024

Umru: Fragments from the Hydrosocial Cycle of Valle Umbra

Mahler & LeWitt Studios Residency, Spoleto

Geographer in residence.

This project is developed in collaboration with visual artist Cecilia Ceccherini and part of Mahler and LeWitt Studios' Materia program. As a collaborative practice bridging geography with the visual arts, the project maps an embodied and effective exploration of water assemblages of the Valle Umbra, asking how we might reinvent hydrosocial territories and shape them towards a more conscious and environmentally just future. Working in the form of text, sound and textile, the results of this research will be presented in June 2024 as part of Spoleto's Festival dei Due Mondi through an exhibition and an associated independent publication.

2017

Cittadella di Alessandria: Scenari di riuso adattivo

Department of Architecture and Design (DAD), Politecnico di Torino

Research assistant. Principal investigator: prof. M. Robiglio

This research was commissioned by Compagnia di San Paolo with the goal of investigating scenarios of adaptive reuse for the Cittadella di Alessandria, a military complex dating to the second half of the Seventeenth century, beyond its current state of under-utilization. The involvement of my expertise in the project consists in the spatial analysis of existing architectural structures and a qualitative survey around the existing use strategies of the Cittadella as an architectural and environmental complex. The latter has involved the organization and fulfillment of a short ethnographic program that worked as a springboard for designing scenarios of adaptive reuse.

Publications

A list is also available online.

Journal articles	2025	Valz Gris, A. (forthcoming). Ragioni, attori e strumenti della finanziarizzazione delle infrastrutture urbane: una mappatura concettuale. <i>Rivista Geografica Italiana</i> - Open Access
	2025	Silvestro, E., Valz Gris, A., Salone, C. (2025). Per una political economy degli hinterland logistici: i regimi territoriali della logistica. <i>Semestrale di Studi e Ricerche in Geografia</i> .
	2024	Valz Gris, A. (2024). Estrattivismo e urbanizzazione: Diseguaglianze e conflitti nell' inserimento strategico del Salar de Olaroz. <i>Rivista Geografica Italiana</i> - Open Access, 3. https://doi.org/10.3280/rgioa3-2024oa18428
	2023	Valz Gris, A. (2023). Beyond the boom. Genealogies of corridor urbanism in the making of the Lithium Triangle, Argentina and Chile. <i>Geoforum</i> , 147, 103913. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.geoforum.2023.103913
	2022	Valz Gris, A. (2022). Cosco e l'urbanizzazione «turbolenta» del porto del Pireo. <i>Territorio</i> , 103, 31–36. https://doi.org/10.3280/TR2023-103003
	2022	Valz Gris, A., Iacovone, C., Safina, A., Pollio, A., Governa, F. (2022) Il 'campo' geografico di un'etnografia sottile. <i>Rivista Geografica Italiana</i> - Open Access, 1(1), 5-31. https://doi.org/10.3280/rgioa1-2022oa13364
	2020	Iacovone, C., Valz Gris, A., Safina, A., Pollio, A., Governa, F. (2021) Breaking the distance: Dialogues of care in a time of limited geographies. <i>Dialogues in Human Geography</i> , 10(2), 124-127. https://doi.org/10.1177/2043820620934940
	2019	Valz Gris, A. (2019) Tangling a bi-oceanic corridor. <i>Lo Squaderno</i> , 51, 17-20.
Book chapters	2025	Governa, F., Ramondetti, L., Safina, A., Sampieri, A., Valz Gris, A. (in press). Beyond the logistical monolith. Multiplicity and differentiation along the Adriatic Corridor. In Apostolopoulou, E., Cheng, H., Silver, J., Wiig, A. (Eds.), <i>The Material Geographies of the Belt and Road Initiative</i> (pp. 261-281). Bristol: Bristol University Press.
	2024	Ramondetti, L., Salone, C., Silvestro, E., Valz Gris, A. (2024). Attori e spazi della logistica contemporanea: Alcune considerazioni sulle piattaforme di Rivalta Scrivia e Piacenza e sul Porto di Trieste. In Armondi, S., Di Vita, S., Galimberti, B. (Eds.), <i>Geografie Operazionali nel Nord Italia: Figurazioni e Strategie Spaziali</i> (pp.138-148). Roma-Milano: Franco Angeli.
	2020	Valz Gris, A. (2020) Logistica e urbanizzazione: Uno sguardo dal corridoio bi-oceanico. In Benvegnù, C., Cuppini, N., Frapporti, M., Milesi, F., Pirone, M. (Eds.), <i>Logistica e America Latina</i> (pp.174-182). Bologna: Dipartimento delle Arti, Università di Bologna. https://doi.org/10.6092/unibo/amsacta/6434
	2019	Valz Gris, A. (2019) Appunti su città e piattaforma. Dentro e oltre la metafora. In <i>Il Campo di Battaglia Urbano</i> (pp. 95-103). Roma: Red Star Press.
Datasets	2023	Valz Gris, A. (2023) Frontiere della Transizione Energetica. Un database cartografico sui permessi di ricerca per materie prime critiche in Italia. (1.0.0) [Data set]. frontieredellatransizione.it , https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.10058425
Conference proceedings	2024	Bandiera, M., Loi, M., & Valz Gris, A. (2024). Racconti dai margini dell'urbanizzazione: Appunti per una geografia ruderale. In IV Edizione delle Giornate di Studi interdisciplinari "GEOGRAFIA E..." - <i>Geografia e Ecologia Politica</i> , Milano.
	2022	Valz Gris, A. (2022) Il paesaggio operativo del Salar de Olaroz (Argentina): Diseguaglianze e conflitti spaziali delle catene globali del valore. In Amato, F., Amato, V., de Falco, S. La Foresta, D. Simonetti, L. (Eds.), <i>Catene/Chains, Memorie Geografiche</i> , 21, 43-48.
	2018	Valz Gris, A. (2018) Lavoro, spazio, movimenti. Mobilitare l'urbano dentro e oltre il capitalismo delle piattaforme. In Zaar, M., Capel, H. (Eds.) <i>Las Ciencias Sociales y la Edificación de una Sociedad Postcapitalista</i> . Barcelona: Universidad de Barcelona/Geocrítica.
Book reviews	2020	Valz Gris, A. (2020) City air beyond the city: Can the planetary mine lead us to emancipatory urban futures? <i>City</i> , 24(5-6), 865–870. https://doi.org/10.1080/13604813.2020.1833547
Public writing	2020	Valz Gris, A., Iacovone, C. (2020) Il virus è un prodotto del Capitalocene. <i>Jacobin Italia</i> .

Teaching

2025–now	MSc thesis Politecnico di Milano Co-supervision Title: In the shadow of the transition: extended urbanisation of lithium, water struggles, and the contestation in the Brandenburg forest. Student: Jorge Farah Dabed Caceres
2024–2025	Economia Urbana Politecnico di Torino Course leader Activities completed in this course included 30 hours of lectures, students' supervision in the development of a practical exercise, examination and marking.
2019–2024	Urban Studies Department of Regional and Urban Studies (DIST), Politecnico di Torino Teaching assistant. Course held by prof. F. Governa Activities completed in this course across several years included guest lectures, students' supervision, the organization of reading seminars and examination.
2023	MSc thesis Università di Torino Co-supervision Title: Metabolismo socio-naturale e regimi urbani: la produzione di socio-natura urbanizzata tra immaginari geografici e materialità. Un'analisi di un caso studio delle Valli Orco e Soana. Student: Stella De Luca
2022–2023	Socially Engaged Art Winter Project Accademia Unidee, Biella and ArtEZ Academy, Arnhem Course leader This academic year, the annual exchange with MA Fine Arts students of the ArtEZ academy explored the theme of the Mediterranean as an imagined geography, as a represented and contested space. Coordinating the didactic environment of a mixed group of BA and MA students in Biella involved giving group lectures and individual project development tutorials, culminating in a collective exhibition during ArtEZ Project Festival in the city of Arnhem.
2022–2023	Tecniche di rappresentazione dello spazio Accademia Unidee, Biella Course leader Teaching this semester-long course to first-year BA students in Fine Arts for the Environment involved designing the course syllabus, planning and giving lectures on the fundamentals of cartography, photography and sketching, followed by tutorials on the development of an individual project. Finals exams consisted in the making of an exhibition showing the work developed throughout the course.
2020–2021	Fattori ambientali e geografici dello sviluppo del territorio Department of Regional and Urban Studies (DIST), Politecnico di Torino Teaching assistant. Course held by prof. M. Santangelo Activities completed in this course included sessions of territorial analysis highlighting the role of physical geography in shaping patterns of urbanization and the making of moving-image materials across the design site for supporting the students' activities.
2017–2019	Urban Economics Department of Regional and Urban Studies (DIST), Politecnico di Torino Teaching assistant. Course held by prof. L. Buzzacchi This assistance position in an interdepartmental course at the Bachelor level has involved both lecturing on the subject of urban political economy, supporting the students in the course empirical exercises and marking through the final examination.
2012–2013	Urban and Architectural Design Department of Architecture and Design (DAD), Politecnico di Torino Teaching assistant. Course held by arch. M. Ortalli My involvement in this course consisted in completing design crits with BA level students in Architecture in order to review and support their work-in-progress designs.

Conferences and seminars

2025	In the shadow of containers: opposing, inhabiting and exploiting global infrastructure in Piraeus Paper presentation. TOROBO - Workshop di Geografia Critica. University of Bologna, Italy.
2025	Corridor in the making: how land is made connectable across the port of Genoa and its extensions Paper presentation. Annual Meeting of the American Association of Geographers. Detroit, USA.
2024	Making Porta Romana investible: urban renewal and the techno-politics of mediation, south of Prada Paper presentation. Urban Speculations: Cities, Technologies, Futures. Leuphana University

	of Lüneburg, Germany.
2024	Il "modello Genova": Infrastrutture logistiche, capitalismo di Stato e transizione autoritaria Paper presentation. XIV Edizione della Giornata di Studio "OLTRE LA GLOBALIZZAZIONE": Transizioni/Transitions. Florence, Italy.
2024	Genoa port, logistics hinterlands and the making of a corridor Paper presentation. Sheffield Urbanism Lecture series. Sheffield Urban Institute, UK (online)
2024	Towards domestic green extractivism. A map of critical mineral exploration licenses in Italy Paper presentation. Colloque Ressources du Sous-sol en Tension. Université de Savoie Mont Blanc, Le Bourget-du-Lac, France.
2024	Urban fragments of global infrastructure: voicing resistance and existence along the New Silk Road in Piraeus Paper presentation. Alle Frontiere dell'Urbano International Workshop. University of Applied Sciences and Arts of Southern Switzerland
2024	The urban geopolitics of infrastructure-led development: articulations of State capitalism and the production of infrastructural violence in Piraeus and Genova Paper presentation. RC21 Conference. Santiago, Chile
2023	"It's a shithole, but we are still here". Ecologie politiche urbane lungo la Nuova Via della Seta a Pireo, Grecia Paper presentation. IV Edizione delle Giornate di Studi interdisciplinari "GEOGRAFIA E..." - Geografia e Ecologia Politica. Milan, Italy.
2023	Enclaves and borders. A walking ethnography of Silk Road urbanisation in Piraeus, Greece Paper presentation. Silk road Cities and Beyond International Workshop. Institute of Environmental Science and Technology (ICTA-UAB), Barcelona, Spain.
2022	Questioning Asian urbanism: grounding the Belt and Road Initiative in Piraeus, Greece Paper presentation. The 10th East Asian Regional Conference in Alternative Geography. Taipei, Taiwan (online).
2022	On the shores of tidal development. A grounded analysis of the Belt and Road Initiative in Piraeus, Greece Workshop presentation. Comparative dialogues on the infrastructure-led urbanization of Global China. Malmö, Sweden.
2021	Hinterlands of the Green Transition Paper presentation. EXALT Conference 2021 - Concurrent Crises and Sustainable Futures: Global Extractivisms and Alternatives. Helsinki, Finland (online).
2020	Extractivismo y Logística en América Latina Roundtable. V Congreso de Estudios Poscoloniales - VII Jornadas de Feminismo Poscolonial. Buenos Aires, Argentina (online).
2020	Where the veil remains: preclusion as method in follow-the-thing research Paper presentation. RGS-IBG 2020: On methods of thing-following. London, UK (canceled due to covid-19 pandemic).
2020	Development at the big finance-microfinance nexus: a political ecology of the Cauchari Solar plant, Argentina Paper presentation. NECS 2020: Transitions: Moving Images and Bodies. Palermo, Italy (canceled due to covid-19 pandemic).
2019	Green cities and extractive hinterlands: on the urban infrastructure of commodity production Paper presentation. Infrastructural Futures across Cities of the Global North Workshop. Manchester, UK.
2019	Urbanization along the li-ion network Paper presentation. Annual Meeting of American Geographers. Washington, DC.
2019	Lavoro, Spazio, Movimenti Paper presentation. XV Coloquio de Geocrítica. Barcelona, Spain.

Events organization

2025	The urban geographies of logistics 1 & 2 Session organization (with B. Galimberti). Annual Meeting of the Association of American Geographers. Detroit, USA.
2025	Making the city investable: the State, financial infrastructures and technopolitical powers 1 & 2 Session organization (with C. Iacovone). Annual Meeting of the Association of American Geographers. Detroit, USA.
2025	Probing ghostly infrastructure Workshop organization (with A. Pavoni). PhD programme in Urban and Regional Development. Politecnico di Torino, Italy.
2024	Global infrastructure and urbanization International workshop organization (with A. Pollio, F. Governa). Interuniversity Department of Regional and Urban Studies and Planning, Politecnico di Torino, Italy.
2023	Racconti dai margini dell'urbanizzazione

Professional memberships

2022–now

Global Infrastructure Research Collective

globalinfrastructurecollective.com

The Global Infrastructure Research Collective is an international academic network of geographers and urban scholars focusing on global infrastructure initiatives and their urban dimensions. The collective is committed to providing a platform for interdisciplinary research and collaboration and has organized three international workshops in Malmö, Barcelona and Torino alongside several other events.

2023–now

China Room

chinaroom.polito.it

China Room is an interdisciplinary laboratory where scholars in the fields of architecture, urbanism, and geography study Chinese urbanization processes and urban transformation related to Global China. China Room also fosters collaboration with institutions and universities to share knowledge and provide mutual understanding on urban and architectural practices.

Invited academic activities

2024

Ressources du sous-sol en tension

International workshop, member of scientific committee. Université de Savoie Mont Blanc, France

2022

Infrastructural afterlives. Genealogies of corridor urbanism in the making of the Lithium Triangle

Invited seminar. Urbanism + Landscape Week 2022 - Calibrating Thresholds. Delft, The Netherlands.

2021

Atacama: le infrastrutture della città a zero emissioni

Invited seminar. Spazi di contaminazione- Seminari di geografia critica. University of Bologna, Italy (online).

2020

Lithium: Exploring the frontiers of urbanization

Invited seminar. Department of the Arts, Alma Mater Studiorum. Bologna, Italy.

Funding and awards

2025

Erasmus+ Staff Mobility

Urban Institute, University of Sheffield, UK

2014

Erasmus Thesis Scholarship

Universitat de Barcelona, Spain

2011

LLP/Erasmus Semester Scholarship

École Nationale Supérieure d'Architecture Paris La Villette, France

Languages

Italian mother tongue

English excellent

French excellent

Spanish good

Software

Code Latex, markdown, html

Office Word, Excel, Powerpoint

Adbode InDesign, Illustrator, Photoshop, Premiere

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